

Betting Google's future on AI

From mobile-first to AI-first under
Sundar Pichai

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We've been building the best AI team and tools for years, and recent breakthroughs will allow us to do even more. This past March, DeepMind's AlphaGo took on Lee Sedol, a legendary Go master, becoming the first program to beat a professional at the most complex game mankind ever devised. The implications for this victory are, literally, game changing—and the ultimate winner is humanity.

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Exactly 10 years ago, back in 2016, the tech space was very different from what we're used to now. Smartphones were all the rage back then, and every phone maker was trying to figure out innovations that would give them an edge. But at that time, Google, under the leadership of Sundar Pichai, set out to do something completely different, which tried to reimagine Android from the ground up. Something way more radical.

In the 2016 Founder's Letter, Pichai had stated how Google would become an AI-first company. He said, "We will move from mobile first to an AI-first world." And later, when he set foot on the 2016 Google I/O keynote stage, he announced the launch of Google Assistant. Arguably, this was what laid the foundation for Gemini and all the other AI products Google has launched so far.

Pichai's "quiet approach"

A big part of Google's success comes from the direction that the company gets from a leader like Sundar Pichai. Unlike CEOs who are known to get things done fast and loud, Pichai's style has always been different.

He isn't like Elon Musk or Sam Altman, but instead, Pichai has been known to have a quiet and calm persona. In fact, a report by Business Insider about him reads, "Pichai maintains an almost impressively calm composure in meetings, even in heated discussions, quietly absorbing the conversation around him before weighing in with questions."

He understands how essential it is to get the basics right in a quiet approach before shifting full focus towards the entire model. This is exactly what helped Google transition from a mobile-first company into an AI-first company, and that too without the internal friction that usually destroys large organisations.

From mobile to AI

Well, we know that Google's big move was moving from the mobile phone market (with Android) to focusing more on AI across the company, but let's understand how they deeply implemented it.

If you think about it, Google's main focus has always been on mobile devices, and that came in the form of their operating system, Android. But starting from 2014,